

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

snapcoalition.org/
Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track D

Economic & Fiscal Policy

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 D track: Economic / Fiscal. Produce budget-scoring-quality analysis for a legislative or executive-branch client.

Use Case Description:

This challenge asks teams to analyze a live fiscal or economic issue and produce budget-scoring-quality analysis for a legislative or executive-branch client — the kind of work CBO, JCT, or a state fiscal office would produce.

Problem Statement:

Producing CBO/JCT-quality fiscal analysis for a live economic issue.

- Select a focus: tax policy reform, minimum wage/labor policy, housing affordability & zoning economics, trade/tariff impacts, public pension solvency, or small-business policy.
- Build a baseline using public economic data (BLS, BEA, Census, state revenue offices).
- Model at least two policy scenarios and their projected fiscal/economic effects.
- Identify distributional impacts (who gains, who pays, across income/region/demographic groups).
- Stress-test assumptions against a recession or high-inflation scenario.

Possible Approaches:

- CBO-style scoring — a 10-year budgetary cost/revenue estimate with methodology notes.
- Distributional analysis — model impacts by income quintile, region, or industry.
- Comparative state — benchmark against states/countries that have tried the policy.
- Behavioral economics — incorporate likely behavioral responses into the model.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- 4–6 page policy brief with baseline data, model outputs, and recommendation
- Fiscal/economic model (spreadsheet) with clearly labeled assumptions

- One-page scorecard summarizing costs, revenues, distributional effects
- Slide deck (8–10 slides)
- Process appendix (0.5 page)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Sensitivity analysis showing how results change under different assumptions
- Simple interactive calculator (e.g., “estimate your household’s impact”)
- Comparative case study of a jurisdiction that implemented a similar policy
- A dissenting-view memo arguing the strongest opposing case

Platforms and Tools:

- Data: BLS, BEA, Census Bureau, FRED, state revenue/budget offices, CBO/JCT public reports
- Modeling: Excel/Sheets, Python (pandas/numpy), R
- Legislative tracking: Congress.gov, state fiscal notes

Judging Criteria:

- Rigor & transparency of modeling assumptions — **25%**
- Data quality & sourcing — **20%**
- Distributional/equity analysis — **20%**
- Political & administrative feasibility — **20%**
- Clarity for non-economists — **15%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Use only public, aggregate economic data — no proprietary firm-level or individual tax data.
- Disclose all modeling assumptions and data sources; no black-box models.
- Do not present modeled projections as certainties — communicate ranges.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.